One of the most striking events of the 1960s that caused much distress and changed the map of the Southern Railway was the washing away of an entire train as well as the rail alignments in a cyclone down south. Here's the report of the calamity:

Alert—Cyclone Report

> On 22.12.64, there was a strong wind blowing at about 1800 hrs onwards from north-east side. The sky was clear. There was no rain and there was no hint of any storm or cyclone which would hit Dhanushkodi in the night… From 10 p.m. onwards, the velocity of the wind increased gradually and still there was no rain. At 11 p.m. onwards, there was a high whistling sound with hissing, and rain began to pour down. Due to the pressure of the wind which had by this time approached cyclonic proportions, waves were bigger and higher and at about midnight, the fourth house to mine collapsed due to water and wind… Soon several huts began to collapse and people were running for shelter at the railway station and railway carriages. By this time, the cyclone was increasing in its tempo and waves were rising to a height of 40–50 feet and breaking on the land. Though it was dark, the white foam on the top of the high waves could be seen and that was how the height of the waves could be judged. At this time, rain was falling like a sheet of water and the wind was blowing at cyclonic speeds. Huts were collapsing and people were running helter and skelter to save themselves. There was no time to rescue their belongings as the water was rising high and practically everything was washed away. There are three pucca buildings at Dhanushkodi, one with terraced roof and two with asbestos roofs. Due to the cyclone, roofings of the asbestos roofed buildings were blown away… The wind, rain and tidal waves continued unabated till about 6 a.m. At this time, wind and rain decreased a little. About 6.30 a.m., both wind and rain stopped completely and within a very short time, cyclone wind [*sic*] began to blow from south-west with the same intensity but without rain. Except for a few collapsed huts near the railway station all other huts were washed away… By about 11 a.m. of the 23rd, I could contact Madras and inform the fate which had befallen Dhanushkodi. [13 2]

Till the time this report was filed on the afternoon of 23 December, the fate of the 653 Pamban–Dhanushkodi passenger train that had left Pamban on the night of 22 December at 11.55 p.m., with more than 110 passengers, was not known. It was only after 48 hours, when the railway headquarters issued a bulletin based on the information given by the Marine Superintendent, Mandapam, that the scale of the tragedy came to light. The six-coach passenger train with the steam engine had been washed away along with the railway line and all its passengers, with no survivors.

The story goes that on 22 December, the metre gauge passenger train left Pamban at 11.55 p.m. with 110 passengers, including a group of school students, on board. The train had almost reached, but a few metres ahead of Dhanushkodi, the signal failed. With pitch darkness all around and no indication of the signal being restored, the driver blew a long whistle and